November 2022 and January 2023, as against just 28 in the same period over the past three years. The civic body had to deploy dust suppression vehicles at around eight locations in October, while visitors to Marine Drive were greeted by an anti-smog gun. On October 20, the worsening AQI led I.S. Chahal, Commissioner, Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation (BMC), to call a stock-taking meeting with all stakeholders.

What brought things to such a pass in Mumbai? It's a toxic mix of a number of factors. For years, the city had remained mostly unaffected by extreme air pollution conditions due to its coastal location, peninsular geography and abundant seabreeze that dispersed particulate matter away and kept the air relatively clean. Of late though, that natural geographical advantage seems to be no longer enough. The mushrooming of towers and skyscrapers across the metropolis has obstructed the wind flow, creating air circulation pockets that disrupt the natural cleansing mechanism of the city. To be fair, many experts do say that a natural change in wind conditions in recent weeks, coupled with a rise in temperature after monsoon, could have been the immediate triggers for the recent uptick in pollution, but that doesn't discount the fact that human impact has contributed to a clear decline in air quality.

The air pollution mitigation plan drawn up by the BMC this year identified dust from construction activities, road dust and its suspension, vehicular emissions, open burning of solid waste and garbage, unclean fuel use in households, bakeries, restaurants and other establishments, crematoriums, and a range of industries like casting yards and ready mix concrete plants, as key sources of air pollution. Mumbai has nearly 6,000 active construction sites, in addition to infrastructure and linear projects like the under-construction coastal road that links the western suburbs to south Mumbai, the various ongoing metro railway projects, and road concretisation works, all of which contribute to the increasing dust levels in the city. Industrial emissions are also on the rise, accounting by now for 33 per cent of all emissions, according to the 'Revised Action Plan for Control of Air Pollution in Non-Attainment Cities of Maharashtra' published by the Maharashtra Pollution Control Board (MPCB) in 2019.

After the meeting called by Chahal, various measures were planned to improve the city's air quality. Compulsory 35-feet-high sheet enclosures were made mandatory for construction sites, along with provisions for sprinkler systems. The BMC plans to operate anti-smog guns on 50-60 major roads, along with water fogging and tree plantation drives. Burning of trash in the open has been banned. Non-compliance is supposed to attract a penalty too.

But how far these rules will be followed is anybody's guess. Activists and experts decry these as just stopgap solutions anyway. Environmentalist D. Stalin, director of the NGO Vanashakti, says anti-smog towers or guns won't help, for there is little space for the wind to circulate in a largely built-up city. "The construction patterns are such that one building faces another. So, even if smog towers are operationalised, the air won't circulate," he says. Bhagwan Kesbhat, founder of the NGO Waatavaran, is of a similar opinion. "Using anti-smog guns is like using an air-conditioner in the open. This is arbitrary use of citizens' money," he says, adding that tangible and no-nonsense action against builders who flout construction norms would be a better way to go. "What is needed is urgent action... the BMC must have squads for checks at construction sites and industries." Old commercial vehicles and those that violate pollution norms are also among the contributing factors.

Mumbai's AQI crisis led to political barbs too, naturally. Nationalist Congress Party MP Supriya Sule said acidly on X: "I would like to congratulate this state government (@CMOMaharashtra) and the @mybmc, which has under their astute guidance, helped bring Mumbai onto the world map as the second most polluted city in the world. A truly remarkable feat!", while ex-environment minister and Shiv Sena (UBT) leader Aaditya Thackeray said, "'No one's listening' defines this illegal regime today on issues that matter to people..."

Criticism can spur prompt action. What the government of the day needs to ensure now is that it goes beyond just patchwork measures. ■



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Environmentalist and director of Vanashakti

ALL CHOKED UP

- **Mumbai is facing a worrying air pollution crisis. The AQI crossed 300 in parts of Mumbai like Andheri and Mazgaon in October**
- **The mushrooming of high-rises has impeded the city's air flow, which served as a natural air-cleansing mechanism for years**
- **Mumbai has around 6,000 construction sites, in addition to infrastructure and linear projects, all of which contribute heavily to dust pollution**